

1987

Chipsets—And Creative

May: GIF Predates JPEG

The Graphics Interchange Format (GIF) was first introduced by Compuserve (the first major commercial online service in the US) in 1987 as an alternative to its B&W-only RLE picture format.

This format used a 256-colour palette and could support animations as well as transparency. It also compressed images using a lossless data compression algorithm that reduced file size. Due to the 256-colour restriction in its palette, it was not targeted at the publishing industry but more towards Compuserve's online repository, which stored images. Reasonably large images using the GIF format could be downloaded faster than those using the PCX or MacPaint, format even on relatively slow connections.

With the increase in popularity of the Internet, GIF became one of the two most popular image formats on the internet, the other being the B&W-only XBM format. The JPEG format only arrived in 1992.

August: Creative Music System

Launched in August 1987, Creative Labs launched its first sound board, the Creative Music System, which provided 12 voices and some noise channels.



The new sound card from Creative Labs—in 1987

This card was unsuccessful and lost out to its rival, Yamaha. The Yamaha card was not only an able gaming card but was also able to synthesise music—something the Creative Music System could not do. Its successor, the SoundBlaster, used the same chip found on Yamaha cards and supported additional features like playing and recording digital audio. Creative Labs used an aggressive marketing strategy, calling the cards “stereo” and incorrectly calling it a digital signal processor.